

Background

The future of leadership

1

The use of war as a **metaphor** for business is one that still prevails into the modern day. Take the book *The Art of War*. It dates back to 6th century China and outlines the key techniques for warfare. It is still basic reading for any **military strategist**, but interestingly it has also become a major best-seller on the list of business books for **aspiring managers**. Its tips on **outsmarting** your opponent and winning negotiations make it required reading for many business executives.

2

The metaphor also extends to leadership. The image of the industrialist leading his workers forward seemed to resemble those old romantic paintings of bold heroic generals on horses heading into battle. Even well into the mid-twentieth century, management was viewed as something similar to being an army captain, with your workers obeying like loyal troops.

3

But nowadays, when you ask people to name important leaders of the 20th century, they mention people such as Gandhi or Nelson Mandela, and in business, Bill Gates or Warren Buffet. None of these people fits the stereotypical image of the warring leader. So somewhere in the 20th century, business leaders evolved from authoritarian bosses into ... well, what exactly? After all, leadership nowadays has become much harder to **pin down**.

4

Understanding what leadership is nowadays needs us to understand how the world of work has changed in the **latter** half of the last century. As work has become more specialized and technical, companies require more and more highly-skilled, educated employees. Suddenly, the boss isn't someone who can do everyone else's job as well as their own. He or she (another leadership change!) is surrounded by people more qualified than him or her and so the job is more about making use of people as

resources. Suddenly, the leader seen as a dictator shouting out orders has moved on to the humane listener.

5

That doesn't mean that great leaders don't need any of the qualities of a war leader. At times of crisis or uncertainty, the company will look to their charismatic CEO to lead them out of an economic slump and into a bright, bold, new future. Similarly, founders of companies build their businesses on strong vision and single-mindedness. But it's noticeable that as many successful companies become much larger, the single-minded visionary, who created the company from nothing, eventually withdraws to make way for groups of people, all with different but complementary leadership skills.

6

One business guru, Charles Schwenk, even calls for 'weaker leadership' in these modern times. His argument is that good decision-making emerges from diversity of opinion. He believes that by avoiding the single-vision, the company is prepared for change and flexible enough to respond to any situation. Although few companies would respond well to the idea of 'weak leadership', Schenk illustrates his point by describing how Microsoft, at first, didn't seem to see the significance of the Internet and how it could benefit. Reportedly, the resistance mainly came from the company's founder and leader Bill Gates. However, other managers at Microsoft continually **lobbied** Gates until he agreed that Microsoft should offer Internet services. This, Schwenk believes, is an example of where weakening your leadership style allows diversity of opinion to succeed and make (what turned out to be) a wise decision.

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So what next for leadership and where will it come from? Will it be stronger or weaker? More dominant or more equal? So far in this century, the leaders who **empower** as opposed to those only seeking power are winning the battle.